

The Explosive Athlete Mentality

This might sound a bit far-fetched at first, but the athletes who achieve the best results are the ones with the best mentality towards training. No matter how good the program is, you cannot get results unless your mind and body are working in conjunction towards improvement.

When it comes to vertical jump and explosiveness one of the biggest factors that affects performance is the central nervous system. The CNS (brain/spinal cord) controls all movement. When you train for vertical jump improvements, you're basically asking your central nervous system to recruit MORE fast twitch muscle fibers and to activate them FASTER.

Essentially, if you want to jump higher and become more explosive you have to convince the brain first. Athletes who show up to workouts and go through the motions without visualizing, focusing, and "zoning in" will train the body but NOT the brain and will achieve poor results.

Additionally, athletes who carry pre-conceived mental barriers such as "my vertical is maxed out" or "I can't jump high because of genetics" are subconsciously communicating with their central nervous system and telling it NOT to improve. You may not know it, but your mental barriers are killing your true explosion potential.

Think about it like this... WHY would your central nervous system work overtime recruiting additional fast twitch muscle fibers if it's being told "THERE'S NO POINT, WE'RE MAXED OUT". It's like a student going into his calculus final with a low "F" — He probably won't pull all-nighters studying because he knows that no matter how good he does it won't be enough.

Now, the athlete that wakes up in the morning and visualizes his workout, pictures himself improving, and knows that he can drastically improve his vertical jump is subconsciously communicating with his central nervous system and saying, "I'M READY TO IMPROVE, LET'S DO THIS!". His nervous system will be more than willing to kick it into high gear and activate every last fast twitch muscle fiber in his body.

The body will perform optimally if, and only if your mind gives it permission.

To adopt an "explosive athlete's mentality" there are 3 areas that you will need to focus on: Pre-Workout Zone, Workout Zone and Post Workout Zone.

Pre-Workout Zone

The pre workout zone lasts from when you wake up to when you begin your workout. After breakfast look over your workout for the day. Throughout the day you should be visualizing

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the workout. Visualize yourself doing each exercise and cranking out personal record after personal record. Know EXACTLY what you need to do to improve.

If it's a plyometric day visualize yourself jumping higher than you ever have. Paint a vivid picture of how explosive you will move on all of the agility drills.

Carry this same visualization into the warm-up. As you're going through your dynamic warm-up really try to zone in. If it's a strength day visualize yourself busting out a perfect set of squats with heavier weight than you could have previously lifted. If you can mentally take yourself there it will be a lot easier to physically take yourself there in the workout!

Tell yourself the results you expect from the upcoming workout. While it may be a bit exaggerative this is what I tell myself before I begin the workout— "I WILL gain 1 inch on my vertical TODAY. I WILL introduce my body to a new level of explosiveness on EVERY set. Every set, every rep I WILL get better."

This level of mental preparation is what convinces your central nervous system to enter the "improvement zone". Purposeful visualization and high expectations for results will prime your nervous system for success!

Workout Zone

The workout zone consists mostly of visualization in-between SETS. Depending on the workout type, you will have anywhere from 20 seconds to 2 minutes of rest time in-between sets. This is the PERFECT time to turn the mind on and turn the body off.

For explosive strength, plyometrics and agility you must visualize yourself completing the next set at a whole new level of speed/explosiveness. It's good to develop little mental cues that you can say to yourself to get your nervous system firing at the level you need. One of my favorite cues is "cannon". Think of how quickly/explosively a cannon fires off a cannon ball. Now think of yourself utilizing THAT SAME LEVEL of speed and explosion on your next set.

Some athletes use cues like "Westbrook". Simple, but effective.

Another thing that is crucial for in-between set visualization is accuracy. Visualize HOW that set is going to feel. Be realistic and detailed in your visualization. Imagine the set from start to finish, including fatigue and self-doubt—and visualize yourself overcoming it.

Post Workout Zone

The post workout zone takes place from your post workout stretch to when you go to sleep. As you are stretching allow your body to enter a complete state of relaxation. Begin thinking about the improvements you've made during the workout. Replay all the highlights.

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As you transfer out of this “Sports Center” mode, start visualizing where you want to be after the program. Every evening visualize your dream dunk—windmill, tomahawk, whatever matches your goals.

Your body is in recovery mode, but your mind should be in results mode. Tell yourself today’s workout improved your vertical by 1 inch. Believe it.

“Those who believe they can do something and those who believe they can't are both right.”
– Henry Ford